

KF47 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

We are exploring KF Confession 11:

We take responsibility for any damage that we have done.

KF Confession 11 is perhaps the most difficult confession to put into practice. Nancy hopes that the meditation techniques that you are learning will strengthen you for this task. All of us have inherited debts of misorientation, and we ourselves have generated debt. We have damaged the material world, our communities, and our own lives. We need to be reminded of these facts so that we can take responsibility for our present outcomes and get on with the glorious work of redeeming our debts. In this lesson, we will be reviewing some of our KF meditations while lifting our eyes and imagining that the sun is shining on our face.

The Sunlight Meditation

Take a meditation posture. Gently close your eyes and begin **Alternate Nostril Breathing**. Practice for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause. Keep your eyes closed and return to normal, relaxed breathing.

Through your KF training, you have learned that the events in your life are not the problem. Misorientation is the problem, and misorientation is caused by your reactions to those events. Now let's return to the **Lectio Divina** meditation using a passage from the Gospel of Mark. Our text is a little longer than usual, and I will read it twice during the next minute. Allow the meaning to soak into your soul. Let's begin.

Do you not see that what goes into a person from the outside cannot defile that person?

What defiles you is what comes out of you.¹

(Pause for 1 minute, repeating the passage after 30 seconds)

Hold this Scripture in your mind while you gently lift your eyes. You might feel a tiny stretch. Imagine what

light and heat from the sun might feel like on your face. For two minutes, try to maintain that sensation as you continue to meditate on our text.

Do you not see that what goes into a person from the outside cannot defile that person?

What defiles you is what comes out of you.

(Pause for 2 minutes, repeating the passage after 1 minute)

Pause. Take a deep breath, and you might like to stretch your whole body. Gently open your eyes and re-engage with the meeting. During the next thirty seconds, jot down anything you learned or felt during this meditation. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Our hymn, *Great Is Thy Faithfulness*, describes the trustworthy flow of created cycles:

Summer and winter, and springtime and harvest,
Sun, moon and stars in their courses above,
Join with all nature in manifold witness
To Thy great faithfulness, mercy and love.²

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

Misorientation is revealed through the poor quality of our relationships. When we live in misorientation, we first damage ourselves. Others who are in relationship with us are then forced to accommodate that damage, which in turn damages them. As a result, energy that could be used for the development of their True Self is hijacked into accommodating our misorientation. One of the most important goals of Karis Fellowships is to help you rebuild the relationships in your community. You can only do that if you are restoring and developing your True Self. Think about your own relationship problems. How often are your relationships damaged because of your insecurities, your pride and self-hate, and your egocentric needs and greed? You can use your KF tools—the **Two Paths Flowchart**, the worksheets, and mindfulness techniques—to help you pause and take responsibility for how you think and feel, *before* you take action. You are learning to choose your responses based on what you know about love. As your True Self develops, you will have more and more capacity to extend yourself and pursue the adventure of fostering your own and another’s development.

Taking responsibility for the damage that you have done begins with taking responsibility for your own orientation. You cannot rebuild damaged relationships if you continue in your own misorientation. So, at this point, you might still need to focus on training your True Self rather than looking for ways to rebuild a relationship. Once you have begun to reorient your life, what practical steps might you take to restore damaged relationships?

Each person is really like an island, a universe of their own, and each person speaks a kind of subconscious language. So, if you want to understand another person, you need to learn their language. In order to do that, you may need help. If you have the resources, take the opportunity to see a skillful and reputable counselor. Talk therapy can be very helpful. Even if you feel that nothing is wrong in your relationships,

relationships can always use a tune-up. Through psychological testing and reflective feedback, an experienced therapist can help you observe the reality of your relationships. You can also look for gifted people in the community who are willing to listen and help you understand yourself. The book *Getting the Love You Want* offers insights and exercises designed to help repair a damaged relationship.³

Pia Mellody, a therapist and author who specializes in the treatment of codependency, suggests that we ask ourselves this question: *Would I talk to or treat a person that I am just getting to know in the way that I am treating this person who is close to me?*⁴ (Repeat) You might ask yourself, “Would I shout at, make demands on, or be rude and sulky with a person I have just met? Would I ignore them, shame them, or impose my opinions on them?” Most probably the answer is no. When you ask yourself these questions, you show your willingness to humbly consider the possibility that you are abusing someone close to you. You can also rephrase these questions to help you evaluate whether you are being abused by someone else. Ask yourself: “Would this person shout at others like they shout at me? Would they be rude and sulky with others like they are with me?” Consider whether someone close to you is treating you with aggression or, perhaps, indifference. Are they imposing on you information that is inappropriate or distasteful? If so, they may be abusing you, and if that is the case, you will need to set some boundaries and get some help. As you find ways to stop participating in the abuse, you might also remember that the abusive person is probably tortured by self-hate. Learn how to protect yourself as you compassionately stick to your own business.

You can invest in your relationships by developing habits of positive interaction, such as demonstrating good manners no matter how you feel, speaking words of appreciation and gratitude no matter how you feel, and offering small services no matter how you feel. Here is another tool: when you have indulged in a misoriented interaction with another person, you might need to withdraw and reorient to your True Self and to God by doing a worksheet or intervention. After you have examined the pride and fear that drove you to participate in the interaction, you might return to the person involved and ask if they would be willing to consider with you how the conversation could have been more oriented and productive. Although you may be very resistant to learning habits that build trustworthy relationships, your choice to humbly enter into this training demonstrates trustworthiness and helps everyone involved make more oriented choices in future interactions. Consider how these habits of positive interactions benefit both you and your community. Children who listen to polite parents learn to be polite—and parents will appreciate that training when their children become teenagers. So, for everyone’s well-being, it is imperative that parents create a culture of positive interaction in the family.

Another tool for building positive interaction is called SET—S-E-T—which stands for Support, Empathy, and Truth.⁵ In all your communication with others, you can generate a more positive flow by showing support and empathy before sharing your truth. Learning to do this is not easy without mindfulness training. Using S-E-T might feel awkward and inefficient at first, but with practice you will be able to go through the steps quickly and with growing confidence. The positive energy that you bring to the encounter is more effective than a perfect technique.

S stands for Support

Encourage the person by acknowledging their value in your eyes. Sometimes people are just looking for the reassurance that you don’t hate them as much as they hate themselves. Now that you know how to believe rather than judge, you can listen for a short time without being under strain. You don’t always need to say something. Sometimes support can be expressed by taking a few moments to simply listen while another person expresses their reality. When you support others in their distress, you let them know that you value them and will try to understand, rather than judge, what they are experiencing.

E stands for Empathy

All the steps of S-E-T are important. Just listening or making supportive noises is not enough to move a relationship forward. In fact, it can create a relationship where you are the sounding board for someone else's chronic self-hate. That's not healthy for either party. You can express compassion without allowing yourself to be used. In the FAITH process, we are reminded that our feelings are common to all human beings—and you know how distressing those feelings can be. If someone is distressed, you can show them that you are aware of their feelings. You might try to restate what they have said, perhaps using their own vocabulary, to assure them that you are trying to understand. If you are helping a small child, you might try drawing a picture to help them talk about their feelings. Sometimes, people, and especially children, just need to hear words that describe what they are experiencing. By offering these words, you let them know that they are not alone in their feelings. Even if you can't find the exact words, you can tell someone what you feel in your body as you are listening. You might then encourage them to observe their own body and share what they are experiencing.

T stands for Truth

When you have shown others support and empathy, they might be less defensive when you speak your truth moderately. You may need to begin with a worksheet to help you let go of judgment and speak in a moderate way. Moderate means that your expression is based on your reality, perception, and experience without the force of judgment. It is important to learn to stop blaming others and telling them who you think they are or what you think they are doing. You now know that you are not qualified to judge what is going on in someone else, so the truth that you speak will be about you and not about them. You are the expert on yourself, and just as you are not qualified to judge another person's reality, no one can authentically judge or evaluate your reality. You need to let others know, in a moderate way, what is going on inside you, and if they are willing to listen, you may even be able to explain your choices. Here is one formula you might try: *When you say (or do) [. . .], I feel [. . .] because I believe that [. . .]. (Repeat)* For your own statement, fill in the blanks. Communicating your feelings in this way helps you take responsibility for your own reality and may help someone else understand you better. Notice that the phrase leaves out the idea that someone else is *making* you feel a certain way. What you feel is usually based on your own story. Although another person is rarely causing you to feel a certain way, they may be triggering some of your existing judgments, stories, fears, and feelings. You have been practicing the skill of observing your feelings without judgment, and you are learning to describe and name those feelings. You can now share them without accusing or attacking.

Here are some examples:

"When you don't tell me the truth, I feel irritable and anxious because I believe that you are hiding important information that I need."

"When you can only see the negative side of this outcome, I feel discouraged because I believe that you don't value my efforts."

If others can't listen to you without having strong reactions, you might try writing them an email, following the steps of S-E-T: Support, Empathy, Truth. An email provides a natural boundary that protects you from the recipient's chaotic feelings and self-defensive reactions. Writing gives you a chance to state your reality clearly and gently, and it gives the other person as much time as they need to calm down and review your thoughts before they respond. By sending an email, you at least give them the opportunity to consider the option of offering an honest and respectful response. Before you send that email, you might invite someone you trust to read it and help you think through what you want to say. Keep your email short and to the point. Avoid any dramatic or judgmental language. You may be able to use each

step of SET in one conversation, or you may need to spend days or even weeks on S and E before the other person can hear your T.

Now that you have tools to help you make choices out of your True Self, give your relationships a chance to heal. However, not all of your relationships can be saved immediately—or even saved at all. Sometimes it is healthiest for both parties if, for a time, you stop trying to fix a relationship and just work on yourself. You may need some space to orient yourself and grow before you attempt to reestablish the relationship. As you work on developing your real potential and expressing your real glory, your relationships start to reflect that change. You move into new territory and learn to let go of old things, including some of your relationships. You can also let go of old misoriented patterns of relating to those close to you, and you can renew those permanent relationships by offering to them your True Self. When you were living in misorientation, you weren't trustworthy in your relationships because you were not offering an authentic expression of yourself. When you live out of your True Self, you are finally honest and fair. You are on firm ground. You become a person that others can trust. By offering your reality, you adventure into real relationships that have within them the power to release potential and change lives.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord Jesus, help me heal damaged relationships by offering my True Self. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

We take responsibility for any damage that we have done.

Last week, we learned about the woman with the hemorrhage who took responsibility for her health and made it a priority by directing her resources of money, abilities, and time toward solving her problem. Through her long years of struggle, she developed active courage and endurance. When the time was ripe, her mature courage, orientation, and endurance allowed her to seize her opportunity with Jesus.

Now we will look at **Ephesians 4:28-32**. This is my translation with a little paraphrase.

²⁸I say to the one who has been stealing—stop stealing. Instead, labor to the point of fatigue for the practical good things so that you may have something to share with others who are in need. ²⁹Let no rotten and worthless reasoning proceed out of your mouth; rather, when there is a need, build up the community by saying the good that you know so that you give a karis gift to those who are listening. ³⁰And do not cause pain to the Holy Spirit of God, in whom you were enclosed and sealed to be, one day, ransomed in full. ³¹Let all bitterness of temper, passion, wrath, outcry, and railings against others be lifted off you, together with all damaging misorientation. ³²Become kind—doing useful things to benefit each other—full of compassion and karis invitations to others, even as God, through the gift of Christ, karissed you.

Take a deep breath.

When you were living in misorientation, you were stealing from your community and from God in order to support your Idol Self. Now, your days of worthless reasoning that caused so much turmoil are over, and you are laboring, often to the point of fatigue, to develop your True Self so that you might serve your community according to your design. Out of this growing potential, you will be able to offer kindness and practical help to others. That offering is a karis gift to the community, and it shows God that you are trustworthy. Ultimately your karis gift is to God, and your trustworthiness invites Him into more relationship with you.

In the **TAT** intervention,⁶ you are guided to ask forgiveness for the damage that you have caused by your “rotten and worthless reasoning”.⁷ Your disharmony has damaged God’s purposes, and it has harmed the community. Self-hate often expresses itself through bitterness, wrath, and blaming others. These feelings and choices let you know that you are misoriented. In spite of such feelings, you can engage your will and choose to be kind by doing useful and helpful things with compassionate understanding. This is one way that we can lose the life of our Idol for Christ’s sake, and in losing it you offer to the community the karis gift of your True Self—the self that is cooperating with God. Through you, God extends a karis invitation to your community. When you give the gift of your True Self, you are demonstrating that you are a child of God; you are following the example of your heavenly Father, who gave the gift of His True Self to redeem this messed-up world. He put aside His very just wrath and offered us Jesus as a karis gift.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father, I want to offer Your karis to others. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water, and you might prepare to take some notes. Assume your meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider a relationship in your life that has been damaged. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider a relationship in your life that has been damaged*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you may be experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to rest in your awareness as you *consider this damaged relationship*. You might notice a compulsion to justify your position or to push away oriented reasoning. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider a relationship in your life that has been damaged*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. For example, you might recognize what anger, shame, guilt, or hurt feels like in your body. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to observe the uncomfortable sensations, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this damaged relationship*. Jesus might ask if you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or numb? Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you judge this damage as good or evil? *(Pause)* Have you often found yourself in a damaged relationship? *(Pause)* Are you experiencing hurt pride or fear? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created us to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have felt just like you feel when they have damaged their relationships. You are a human creature. *(Pause)* Feelings are just chemical reactions in your body bringing you information. With training, you can choose what you will do with that information. *(Pause)* Rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting, you can breathe with compassion for everyone living with damaged relationships. Help your body process through a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for bringing us together for healing and training. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to the truth about our relationships. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to further our connection with our True Self and design, with our community, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

*If you have invited someone to the NHG study, be sure to ask them how the study is going for them.

*(*Except in Jubilee Year)*

¹ Mark 7:18.

² *Great is Thy Faithfulness* by Thomas Chisholm (1866–1960), www.youtube.com/watch?v=dTKlqmdfHSk.

³ en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Harville_Hendrix.

⁴ www.google.com/search?q=Facing+Codependence.

⁵ www.chrisakins.com/communicating-effectively-in-difficult-situations/.

⁶ See KF25.

⁷ Eph. 4:29 in Nancy's translation.